

On the decomposition of a strong epimorphism into regular epimorphisms

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July 13, 2026. CT2026

This talk is based on a preprint [arXiv: 2604.05744](https://arxiv.org/abs/2604.05744).

This work was supported by JSPS KAKENHI Grant Numbers JP24KJ1462, JP25KJ1474.

1 The decomposition number

2 Minimum vs. canonical

Regular-epi decomposition

Recall: the fundamental theorem of homomorphisms

For $A \xrightarrow{f} B$,

$$A / \text{Ker}(f) \quad \underbrace{A / \text{Ker}(f)}_{\text{the coeq. of the kernel pair}} \cong \text{Im}(f)$$

the smallest s

Equivalently, the unique morphism f_1 becomes mono:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} A & \xrightarrow{f} & B \\ & \searrow \text{reg. epi} & \nearrow f_1 \\ & \text{Coim } f := A / \text{Ker } f & \end{array}$$

The theorem holds in any categories of equational algebras.

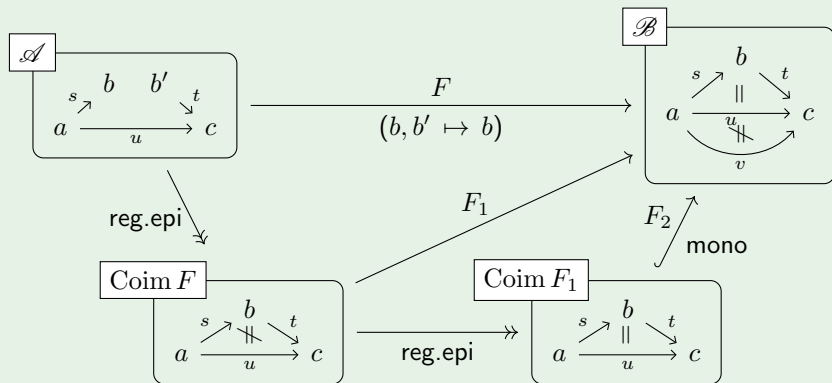
Question

Does the theorem hold in any category? $\rightsquigarrow$ No.

The case of Cat

Counterexample

In Cat,



The decomposition number

Definition [GU71; MS82; Bör91; KN26]

- 1 The (canonical) decomposition number $\sigma(f) :=$ the smallest α s.t. " f_α " becomes mono.
- 2 For a category $\mathcal{C}$, $\sigma(\mathcal{C}) :=$ the smallest β s.t. $\forall f$ in $\mathcal{C}$, $\sigma(f) < \beta$.

Example

- 1 $\mathcal{C}$: a variety $\rightsquigarrow \forall f, \sigma(f) \leq 1 \rightsquigarrow \sigma(\mathcal{C}) \leq 2$. eg. $\sigma(\mathbf{Set}) = \sigma(\mathbf{Grp}) = 2$.
- 2 $\sigma(\mathbf{Pos}) = 2$.
- 3 $\sigma(\mathbf{Field}) = 1$.
- 4 $\sigma(\mathbf{Cat}) = 3$ [BBP99].

Theorem [GU71]

$\mathcal{C}$: locally κ -presentable $\rightsquigarrow \sigma(\mathcal{C}) \leq \kappa + 1$.

However, this only provides a loose upper bound $\sigma(\mathbf{Cat}) \leq \omega + 1$.

Giving a tight upper bound

$\mathcal{C}$: locally presentable

Task: Find as tight an upper bound for $\sigma(\mathcal{C})$ as possible.

Strategy:

- 1 Construct a logical theory $\mathbb{T}$ s.t. $\mathbf{Mod} \mathbb{T} \simeq \mathcal{C}$.
- 2 Looking closely at $\mathbb{T}$, we obtain an upper bound.

Theorem (informal) [KN26]

This strategy works well if $\mathbb{T}$ is a *partial Horn theory* [PV07] or a *generalized algebraic theory* [Car86].

Application

$$\begin{aligned}\sigma(n\text{-Cat}) &\leq n + 2, & \sigma(\mathbf{StrMonCat}) &\leq 3 \\ \sigma(\mathbf{MultiCat}) &\leq 3, & \sigma(\mathbf{DblCat}) &\leq 4.\end{aligned}$$

In fact, these are equalities!

1 The decomposition number

2 Minimum vs. canonical

Minimum vs. canonical

Recall

$\sigma(f) :=$ the “length” of the **canonical** regular decomposition of f .

How does this relate to **non-canonical** decompositions?

Definition [KN26]

The **minimum decomposition number** $\delta(f) :=$ the shortest possible length of decompositions of f .

Theorem [KN26]

In a category with kernel pairs and colimits,

$$\sigma(f) = \delta(f).$$

That is, “canonical = minimum.” (This can be verified easily.)

Further generalization

We started from:

- regular epimorphisms, and
- the canonical decompositions under them.

→ These can be generalized to a class $\mathbf{E}$ of morphisms that admits *locally orthogonal $\mathbf{E}$ -factorizations* [Tho79; MT82; Tho83].

Example

- 1 $\mathbf{E} := \{\text{strict localizations in } \mathbf{Cat}\}.$
- 2 $\mathbf{E} := \{\text{monotone quotient maps in } \mathbf{Top}\}.$
- 3 $\mathbf{E} := \{\text{strictly monadic functors in } \mathbf{Cat}_{\text{radj}}\}.$

Theorem [KN26]

For a class $\mathbf{E}$ of morphisms that admits locally orthogonal $\mathbf{E}$ -factorizations,

- 1 If $\mathbf{E} \subseteq \{\text{epis}\}$, then $\sigma(f) = \delta(f)$. (Trivial)
- 2 If $\mathbf{E} \not\subseteq \{\text{epis}\}$, then $\sigma(f) = \delta(f)$ but only for finite ordinals. (Non-trivial)

Thank you!

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